quadrupled. Farmhands, now a rare commodity, began to charge exorbitant fees for their labor.[15]

"Many have certainly / Heard it common said," wrote the French poet Guillaume de Machaut,

> How in one thousand three hundred and forty nine,
> Out of one hundred, there remained but nine.
> Thus it happened that for lack of people
> Many a splendid farm was left untilled,
> No one plowed the fields
> Bound the cereals and took in the grapes,
> Some gave triple salary . . .
> Since so many were dead.[16]

So many were dead; and no one agreed on what it all *meant*. The faculty of the medical school in Paris published a report blaming the plague on the conjunction of "three planets in Aquarius," which had caused the "deadly corruption of the air." King Edward III of England, mourning the loss of his fifteen-year-old daughter, blamed the spiritual wickedness of his people. "It was thought," wrote the Florentine Matteo Villani, "that the people, whom God by grace had preserved in life, having seen the extermination of their neighbors . . . would become better, humble, virtuous . . . overflowing with love and charity for one another. But . . . the opposite happened." In France and Germany, Jews were accused of poisoning the wells; hundreds were seized and murdered by angry mobs. From Avignon, Pope Clement VI condemned this violence and composed a Mass for the turning away of plague: *O God, who does not desire the death but the penitence of sinners, we beseech you graciously to turn your people to you . . . mercifully withdraw the flail of your anger from them*.[17]

"We have lost almost everything," wrote the Poet Laureate Petrarch, in a letter to a friend, "and found no rest. . . . Last losses are beyond recovery, and death's wound beyond cure. There is just one comfort: that we shall follow those who went before. . . . The life we lead is a sleep; whatever we do, we dream. Only death breaks the sleep and wakes us from dreaming. I wish I could have woken before this."[18]